KCC CODE CLUB · GAME MAKERS

Venue and Device Checklist

Before you commit to a room

Test before you commit

- [ ] **Wi-fi with fifteen devices actually connected.** Not "the venue has wi-fi". Take five devices down there and stream something on all of them. Community hall wi-fi is very often one consumer router with a fair-use cap, and it falls over at exactly ten connections
- [ ] **Power.** Count the sockets. Fifteen laptops on battery for an hour is usually fine, but you'll want six or eight sockets and a couple of multi-boxes for the ones that arrive at 12%
- [ ] **Projector or a big screen**, and whether your laptop can actually drive it. Bring your own adapter — the venue's will be the wrong one
- [ ] **Tables at a height children can type at**, and enough of them. Laptops on laps for an hour is miserable
- [ ] **Lighting and glare.** Afternoon sun on fifteen screens ruins a session. Check at the time of day you'll actually be running
- [ ] **A wall or whiteboard** for the block lists and working through examples
- [ ] Toilets, and the walk to them
- [ ] Somewhere for parents to wait, if they do

Room layout

Arrange tables so **you can walk behind every single screen**. This is the single most important layout decision and it's usually got wrong.

Rows facing the projector look tidy and are terrible — you can't see what anyone is doing. A horseshoe, or clusters of four with gaps between them, means the floater can see every screen from the middle of the room without leaning over anyone.

Being able to glance at fifteen screens and spot the one that hasn't changed in five minutes is how you catch the quietly stuck child. Design for that.

Devices

Bring your own laptop — and what that costs us

Every child brings their own laptop for the pilot. There is no budget for club machines and no time to source them before week one. That is a real decision with a real cost, so be honest about it rather than hoping nobody notices.

A bring-your-own requirement quietly excludes the families who would benefit most, and they will not tell you that's why they didn't sign up. They will just not sign up. Nothing in this pack fixes that. What you can do:

- **Say it plainly on the parent letter**, in what to bring, so nobody registers and then discovers the problem in week one.
- **Invite them to tell you anyway.** Promise nothing, but ask. A club member with a spare machine in a cupboard is a phone call, not a budget line.

- **Count who it turns away.** Every family that asks and can't come is a number, and that number is the whole case for sponsored laptops after the pilot.
- **Take Chromebooks, and tablets if that's all there is.** See below. A fiddly device beats no device.

Four or five laptops would cover most groups. Worth trying once the pilot has something to show: club members' old machines, a member's workplace refreshing its fleet, a local school, a library, or a community tech recycler. That is a term-two job.

When a child turns up without one, pair them with a neighbour for that session. Two children on one laptop works fine for a week and is enormously better than sending someone home. If it happens twice with the same child, phone the parent — it is usually a logistics problem you can solve, not a child who has gone off it.

Minimum spec

Scratch is not demanding, but it is a browser app and it wants a bit of memory.

Anything modern	Fine — any laptop from the last six or seven years
RAM	4GB works, 8GB is comfortable
Browser	Current Chrome, Edge, Firefox or Safari
Screen	11" minimum, honestly. Smaller than that and the block palette plus the stage plus the code area don't fit together
Mouse	**Bring spare USB mice.** Dragging blocks on a trackpad is genuinely harder, and for an 8-year-old it's the difference between building things and giving up. This is the highest-value $15 you'll spend

Tablets and Chromebooks

- **Chromebooks:** fine. Scratch runs in the browser.
- **iPads and Android tablets:** Scratch works but drag-and-drop on a touchscreen is fiddly for the more complex scripts, and My Blocks in week seven are painful. Workable if it's all a family has; not what you'd choose.
- **Phones:** no.

Before every session

- [ ] Message families the night before: **charge the laptop, bring the charger**
- [ ] Arrive early enough to get everyone logged into Scratch before the session starts
- [ ] One browser tab open on the Scratch editor. Not fifteen tabs, not a games site
- [ ] Spare mice out on the tables
- [ ] Your own presenting laptop charged, with Scratch Desktop on it

When the internet dies

It will. Have this ready and it's a shrug instead of a cancelled session.

This plan is weaker than it used to be, because the laptops are not ours. We can't pre-install anything. Carry the Scratch Desktop installers for Windows and macOS on the USB stick and offer to install them in week one — five minutes per machine, once, and it buys you the fallback below for the rest of the term.

1. **Scratch Desktop** on as many machines as accepted it in week one. Projects save locally.
2. **The USB stick** has last week's `.sb3` files for every student, backed up at the end of every session.
3. Students open their `.sb3` in Scratch Desktop, work normally, and save back to the stick.
4. Upload to their online accounts next week when the wi-fi is behaving.

Anyone without the desktop editor pairs up with someone who has it. Not ideal, better than going home. The recovery takes about five minutes if the backups exist and the session is unsalvageable if they don't — do the backups.

Consumables

Per term, roughly:

- Name stickers for week one
- Printed handouts — 15 copies × 8 weeks
- Pencils and a few pens
- Blu-tack for putting the block lists on the wall
- A whiteboard marker that actually works. Bring your own; the venue's are always dry
- Certificates for week eight
- Snacks for the showcase